

where these norms can be earned. GM M. Shyam Sundar, who has coached the last five GMs to come out of India, explains why.

"Predominantly, 2200-rated players are based overseas. Beating a higher-rated player earns you more rating points and helps in your progression towards achieving a GM norm," he says. "The tournaments are held in and around Europe so that players can stay for two or three months and compete in multiple tournaments during the same trip. India is the lone country in Asia where you can find enough players, making it logistically difficult for others," he adds.

Apart from financial constraints and the dearth of opportunities, the lack of means to undergo coaching from top trainers also posed a problem. "It was mostly trial and error. We assumed we were doing the right things. Later, we realised it was not the right approach. It was very slow progress. Two steps forward, two steps back," says Ramesh, who concedes he was lucky to source chess books from abroad thanks to his father's involvement with the customs department. That option was too far-fetched for many others.

M. S. Thejkumar, India's 50th GM and the first from Karnataka, had to wait nine years after completing his norms to breach the required rating. "I completed my IM title and GM norms within a span of six months. I required around 50 to 60 rating points at that time. Till 2015, I was working on my own. Then I decided to have a few sessions with Ukrainian GM Alexander Goloshchapov. Slowly, over two years, I was able to get the title," he says.

Vijayalakshmi also attested that acquiring the services of an international coach was never an option. Till his death in 2007, her father remained her only coach. His passing deeply affected her, but she is careful not to use that as an excuse. "I'm a very emotional person when it comes to my dad. So, for me, it affected my chess," she says. Motherhood, the demands of a



FOR SHYAM SUNDAR, COACHING GREW OUT OF WHAT HE HAD LACKED AS A PLAYER. FINANCIAL INSECURITY MEANT HE COULD NOT RETAIN A STRONG COACH FOR LONG

full-time job and, later, the disruption caused by the COVID-19 pandemic further reduced the time she could devote to tournament chess.

Vijayalakshmi realised that another serious attempt at the GM title would demand complete immersion. "When I'm playing chess, I should only play chess," she says. With a young son and other responsibilities, that level of

concentration was no longer immediately possible. "I'm an eternal optimist. I will get back to chess in the future and try to reach that rating," she says.

The double Olympiad medallist now runs an online academy, training around 30 students from India and abroad. It was not, however, a career she had imagined during her playing days. "To be very